Q+A

A Dinner to Remember

Chef **Massimo Bottura** of the three-star Michelin restaurant, Osteria Francescana in Modena, Italy, which has also topped the World's 50 Best Restaurants list twice, is in Delhi to cook a few meals

Q. What special surprises can we look forward to at the Delhi dinners?

I don't want to share too much, it's a surprise! What I can say is that I can't wait to be back in India. Thank you to Culinary Culture and The Leela Hotels for organising this wonderful opportunity. With my team, we are preparing two beautiful menus, featuring some of the most iconic dishes from Osteria Francescana!

Q. How would you sum up your food philosophy?

The idea that has led my work and of my team over the past 30 years is of 'Tradition in Evolution'. We see the kitchen at Osteria Francescana as a laboratory, but also an observatory to look at the past in a critical way, not a nostalgic one. Our work is not about forgetting the past but finding the most appropriate way to bring it forward.

Q. What's with the quirky names of the dishes?

Every dish has its story. 'The Crunchy Part of the Lasagna' is about my childhood memories, when my mother would pull out the tray of lasagne from the oven, and my brothers and I would fight over the burned corners of the pan. Then, there's 'Oops! I Dropped the Lemon Tart'. Takahiko Kondo, our Japanese sous chef, dropped a lemon tart one evening. It couldn't be substituted as we were going to serve the last two tarts for the service. So, I took the other one and I broke it... It was so beautiful that we decided to recreate it in the same way thereon.

Q. What's next in the future for Massimo Bottura?

The future cannot be lived in: it is a dream. It is difficult to intuit, even accept, and almost impossible to anticipate. We need to dream it.... and prepare a place for it in our souls. The future is not a place. It is a state of mind....

with Amit Dixit



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